that they are free to do what they liked, but should 'not hurt India' in any which ways.[84] Indian diplomats continued to cultivate Karzai, and encouraged his opponents to accept his authority. Such political balancing was a daunting task for those diplomats who did it, and New Delhi cared little about the fallout if the balancing failed.

Afghan reactions

Unlike the popular goodwill that India enjoys across Afghanistan, narratives about India's political role among Afghanistan's political elite are complex (especially among the Afghan clergy that resents the spread of Indian culture in the country). India's tilt towards Karzai, expectedly, generated two opposite reactions: one critical and other supportive. Karzai's political opponents criticised that India was relying too heavily on one man in a country wrought by political factionalism and instability. By doing so, New Delhi was being biased against its former UF allies. This perception sharply contrasted India's strategic intent towards, and positive self-perception in, Afghanistan. Indian officials, for instance, were convinced about their neutrality in Afghan politics. But the gulf between what India thought it was doing and how Afghans perceived Indian actions grew. Was this a communications failure or was India really biased? To some extent, it was both, and to a large extent, India simply did not mind cold-shouldering any group or personality till they developed an overtly hostile posture towards India.

The perceived zero-sum nature of Afghanistan's politics became a hurdle for the conciliators. Karzai made it difficult for India to engage with his adversaries, while his adversaries blamed India for not paying adequate attention to their grievances against Karzai. Even when Indian diplomats agreed with the opposition that Karzai was manipulating them to remain in power, it could do little to change that. The deep aversion and mistrust between different Afghan political factions throughout 2002–15 only compounded these pressures. Mohammad Halim Fidai, former governor of Wardak, stated that his biggest worry was the possibility of another round of Afghan civil war due to fallout between different factions in active Afghan politics, and not due to the